

23 March 2026

The National Food Council (the Council) met for the second time on Monday 23 March 2026. The meeting was chaired by the Secretary of the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Victoria Anderson.

The Secretary welcomed members and outlined the meeting's focus on national security, the conflict in the Middle East and impacts on food supply chains and critical inputs. The Secretary noted supply chain challenges and national resilience were part of the original impetus for the National Food Security Strategy (the strategy). The current conflict highlights the importance of considering national security and resilient supply chains as part of the strategy's development.

The Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, the Hon Julie Collins MP, addressed the Council, outlining the coordinated response from government to minimise the impacts of the conflict and support farmers with some of the immediate challenges, including the work the government is doing with industry. The Minister noted the importance of the Council considering the current conflict and members' insight into how farmers and stakeholders across the food supply chain can be supported in the short-term as well as what the strategy should consider in the medium-to-long-term to set our food system up to be prepared for future disruptions.

The Department of the Prime Minister and Cabinet provided an overview of Australia's strategic environment and national and regional security implications for Australia's food security. Members discussed opportunities to improve Australia's food security including strengthening resilience in food supply chains in the context of national security risks. Members reflected that resilient supply chains are critical not only for production, processing and distribution but for a stable and accessible food system for all.

The Council heard from ABARES on the likely impacts of the Middle East conflict on agriculture, as well as from the Australian Logistics Council on supply chain resilience for food, fuel and freight.

The Council was updated on the range of work underway across government to address the immediate challenges.

Members noted the conflict demonstrates the importance of fuel and other key inputs such as fertiliser for production. The Council agreed that fuel security is fundamental to food security, essential for production and distribution right along the supply chain all the way to the consumer.

The Council recommended urgently exploring early actions under the strategy to address supply chain issues, in parallel to the work already underway to consider issues and challenges across the broader food system. Members recommended that government continue to prioritise communication with the community on the impact of the Middle East conflict on the food supply chain. This would also support industry decision-making and guide the work being undertaken across government and industry.

The Council supported, as an early action to support development of the strategy, an urgent targeted food supply chain assessment as announced by Minister Collins on 23 March 2026. It will initially focus

on liquid diesel supply chains, and will then expand to other critical agricultural inputs, including crop protection products and fertilisers. This work was already underway but will now be fast-tracked. This will feed into the Government's Fuel Supply Taskforce, led by Ms Anthea Harris.

The Council noted Andrew Henderson will lead the food supply chain assessment funded by AgriFutures Australia. Andrew will step down from the Council and the Minister and Chair thanked him for his contribution.

The Council welcomed the appointment of Mr Simeon Gilding as a new member of the Council.

While the focus of the meeting was on the current impacts of the Middle East conflict and the need for urgent, early action, the Council acknowledged the need to remain focussed on the broader and longer-term opportunities and challenges for the food system. This includes equitable access to affordable, healthy food, strategic trade and supply chain relationships, productivity and innovation.

The Council also received an update on the co-design process to date including an overview of the sessions held, and early themes emerging. Members noted workshops are being held around the country with a range of stakeholders, delivering on the commitment to an open and consultative process for developing the strategy.

Attendees

- Dr Christopher Downs
- Mel Gatfield
- Andrew Henderson
- Barry Irvin AM
- Dr Leisa McCarthy
- Claire McClelland
- Su McCluskey
- Pat O'Shannassy
- David Stout
- Dr Tracy Sullivan
- Mr Simeon Gilding
- The Hon Julie Collins MP, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Victoria Anderson, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (Chair)
- Matt Lowe, Deputy Secretary, Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry Policy Group
- Joanna Stanion, First Assistant Secretary, Agricultural Policy Division
- Paul Denny, Assistant Secretary, Food Policy Branch

Guest attendees

- John Body, ThinkPlace
- Cameron Heath, Assistant Secretary, Defence Policy and Capability, Department of the Prime Minister and Cabinet

- Dr Jared Greenville, Executive Director, ABARES
- Dr Hermione Parsons, Chief Executive Officer, Australian Logistics Council

Apologies

- Dr Elizabeth Jackson

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/national-food-council-mar-2026>